

5.1 Encrypting Your Data

5.1.1 Using Windows XP Pro

The most obvious way of locking away your data is to encrypt it, and this can be done at various levels: encrypting individual files, or folders, or entire drives. Windows XP Professional offers an easy way to encrypt files and folders. Just follow the steps below to ensure no-one who has access to your computer can open certain files or folders. Note that this method doesn't use passwords—the way it works is, when you're logged on, the contents of the file are visible; when someone else logs on as a Guest or under a different login, he won't be able to see the contents of the encrypted files or folders.

To encrypt a file or folder, right-click on it and select Properties. In the General tab, click Advanced. Check the "Encrypt contents to secure data" box.

If you chose to encrypt a single file, you can also choose to encrypt the containing folder. Select "Encrypt the file and the parent folder" in the Encryption Warning dialog window. All files created in the encrypted folder will be automatically encrypted then on.

To decrypt the file or folder you encrypted—which you don't need to do if you're the only person who logs on to your machine—just do the following: right-click on the file or folder, click Properties, and in the General tab, click Advanced. Then clear the "Encrypt contents to secure data" checkbox.

When you decrypt a folder, you need to decide whether to decrypt only the folder or to decrypt the folder and all files and sub-folders in the folder. If you choose to decrypt only the folder, the files and subfolders within the folder will remain encrypted. But when you add new files and sub-folders to the folder, they will not be automatically encrypted.